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Telecom & Networking Equipment | North America

ECOC 2026 Preview: Bringing More Light to Optical's Debates

We will be attending ECOC 2026 next week and will be hosting investor meetings with CIEN, KEYS, CSCO, COHR, and NOK. CPO, OCS and evolution of laser technologies to be in focus. Highly technical show, so see as less market moving, but should be a slight positive to reaffirm strong demand conditions.

Key Takeaways

- ECOC is unlikely to drive meaningful surprises given its technical focus, though investor interest in COHR's PhotonLink platform has been building
- NPO should remain a central ECOC debate following CIOE as investors assess the next architecture to scale beyond pluggables
- Continued upward revisions to transceiver sales post 2Q earnings simultaneously extends runway for pluggables
- Moving from 200G to 400G lanes, evolutions of laser technologies and competitive landscapes to be in focus.

We will be attending ECOC 2026 in Malaga, Spain between September 20-24, 2026 and will host investor meetings with CIEN, KEYS, CSCO, COHR, and NOK.

ECOC should center on how AI networking architectures evolve, with NPO/CPO as a key area of focus. NPO emerged as a key architectural focus at CIOE 2026 (9/9-9/11) and we expect that discussion to carry directly into ECOC as investors assess the next step beyond pluggable optics. We will be hosting investor meetings with **CIEN, KEYS, CSCO, COHR, and NOK**, where discussion should span the progression from 1.6T toward higher-speed interconnects, NPO/CPO and other embedded-optics architectures, laser types, and the evolution of scale-up, scale-out and scale-across connectivity (along with emergence of scale-in). Coherent technology is also moving closer to the datacenter, while power, thermal management, and signal integrity remain important constraints on the pace of architectural change. Notably, COHR has announced ahead of the conference plans to discuss its new PhotonLink platform, a new integrated-optics platform spanning the full optical signal chain from light generation and beam shaping through transmission, detection and conversion back to an electrical signal for the XPU.

NPO increasingly looks like the more practical bridge between pluggables and full CPO adoption. Ahead of ECOC, we expect conversation around how continued upward revisions to pluggable transceiver demand reinforce the runway for NPO as the next logical optical architecture beyond pluggables. NPO places the optical engine adjacent to the switch ASIC while maintaining physical separation between the two components, preserving independent test, rework and replacement while

MORGAN STANLEY & CO. LLC

Meta A Marshall

Equity Analyst

Meta.Marshall@morganstanley.com

+1 212 761-0430

Antonio Jaramillo

Research Associate

Antonio.Jaramillo@morganstanley.com

+1 212 761-4438

TELECOM & NETWORKING EQUIPMENT

North America

Industry View

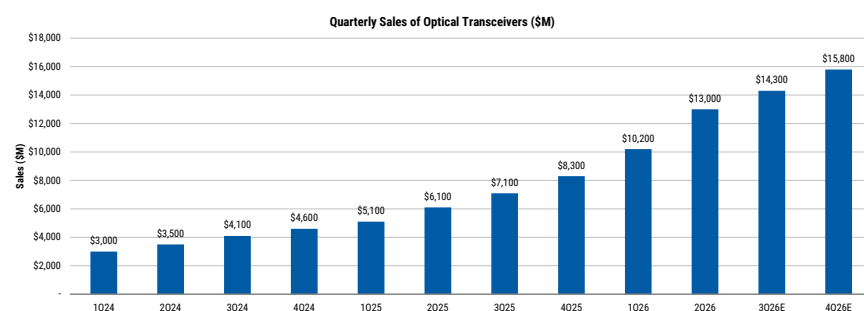
In-Line

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materially shortening the electrical path. As an illustration, an 800G link at ~11W per port for NPO compares with ~30W for a conventional pluggable and ~9W for CPO, implying roughly 63% lower power than pluggables while conceding only ~2W versus CPO. Broader applicability could further support NPO adoption, particularly across non-NVIDIA platforms seeking greater power efficiency without immediately moving to a fully co-packaged architecture. CPO remains the longer-term performance endpoint, but NPO appears increasingly well positioned to sustain the transition from pluggables before full co-packaging becomes necessary.

Exhibit 1: Continued upward revisions to optical transceiver sales in CY26E (~\$40B to ~\$50B) reinforces a longer demand runway, shifting focus toward NPO rather than CPO as the next optical architecture to reach commercial scale



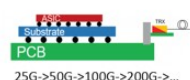
Source: LightCounting

Transition from NPO to CPO will likely be determined by the scaling limits of the electrical interface. As lane rates move from 200G to 400G, higher insertion loss and interface reflections leave less signal-integrity margin for NPO. Successful progress from OIF and Open CPX MSA could preserve NPO viability at higher speeds and extend the architecture into the next generation (something we heard about at CIEN last week).

Exhibit 2: NPO balances cost and technical feasibility

Optical Evolution: From Pluggable to NPO/CPO

Standard Pluggable Optics
(FRO, LPO, LRO)
Fully retimed optics
Linear pluggable optics
Retimed transmitter linear receiver



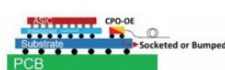
FRO→LPO
Retimer avoided
Insertion loss e.g. 22dB @224G

NPO: Near-packaged optics, is an optical transceiver sitting on PCB by a socket, close to the ASIC, but not co packaged with it.



Retimer avoided
Insertion loss e.g. 10~18dB @224G

CPO: Co-packaged optics, is an optical transceiver sitting on substrate with/without a socket, co-packaged with the ASIC.



Retimer avoided
Insertion loss e.g. 6~10dB @224G

Best technical feasibility, reliability and availability

Source: LightCounting 2026 CPO and NPO Conference

Exhibit 3: Select ECOC sessions across our coverage

Ticker	Date	Time (CEST)	Session / Event Title (verbatim)	Speaker(s)	Room / Location
COHR	Sun, Sep 20	09:00-12:30	Light Sources for Next-generation Optical Communication Systems for AI Datacenters	Dr. Wilfried Mairneut (Organizer)	A1 Auditorium 1
CIEH		11:00-12:30	Breaking the power wall with multi-rail photonics and optical interconnect innovation	Bilal Raz (Sr. Director, Interconnects Product Line Management)	Not specified
CIEH		14:00-15:30	How will we manage the heterogeneous optical communication networks of the future?	David DiGiovanni (Optical Systems Architect)	Not specified
COHR		14:45-15:00	Hybrid Solutions for Very High Speed PON - the Best (or Worst) of coherent and IMDD worlds?	Dr. Noriaki Kaneda	C2.1 Conference room 2.1
CIEH		16:00-17:30	Will the AI workload require an end-to-end-optimized network infrastructure?	Robert Keys (VP, Systems Architecture)	Not specified
CIEH		16:00-17:30	Can fast, narrow channels keep rising without limit or will slow and wide become the winner?	Bilal Raz (Sr. Director, Interconnects Product Line Management)	Not specified
CIEH		16:15-16:30	Future role of coherent technology for data center applications	Kim Roberts (VP, WaveLogic Sciences)	Not specified
COHR	Mon, Sep 21	16:30-16:42	Can Fast Narrow Channels Keep Rising Without Limit or Will Slow and Wide Become the Winner?	Dr. Chris Kocot	PV-R Multipurpose room
CIEH		10:00-10:30	AI cluster communications	Peter Winzer (VP, Systems Architecture)	Not specified
CSCO		10:00-10:15	Strategies for Scale-Across and Scale-Out Networking	Tom Williams (VP, Product Development, Cisco)	Market Focus Theater
CIEH		10:40-10:55	Accelerating CPO broad market adoption	Karen Liu (Interconnects Product Line Manager)	Not specified
NOK		11:15-11:45	Optical components for the evolution of intra-data center connectivity	Neel Patel (General Manager, Nokia Optical Component Technology), Teresa Monteiro (Director of Marketing)	Not specified
NOK		11:20-11:35	Challenges and solutions to build components for 1600G+	Julia Larkova (VP, Product Management, Optical Networks)	Not specified
COHR		11:40-11:55	Cooling Smarter: How Advanced Materials Unlock Datacenter Efficiency	Dr. Sanjai Parthasarathi	Market Focus Theatre: Pavilion 2
COHR		13:00-17:00	Modules and Subsystems	Dr. Sanjai Parthasarathi (Co-Chair)	Not specified
CIEH		14:30-14:45	Algorithmically optimized real-time 18 Tb/s throughput over a 16,608 km trans-Pacific subsea link	Marc Stephens (Sr. Sales Engineer)	Not specified
NOK		15:05-15:35	Pluggable or embedded? Case studies from real world deployments	Fady Masoud (Sr. Director, Solutions Marketing), Oriol Bernet Pardo (Sr. Director, Product Management)	Not specified
COHR		15:30-15:35	Beyond 1.6T: Enabling AI Datacenter Scale with coherent-like Optics	Shawn Esser	Market Focus Theatre: Pavilion 2
CIEH		16:00-17:00	XPO and system scaling	Bilal Raz (Sr. Director, Interconnects Product Line Management)	Not specified
COHR		18:30	Coherent PhotonLink Unveiling at ECOC 2026	Jim Anderson; Dr. Julie Eng; Dr. Beck Mason	Gren Hotel Miramar, Paseo de Reding 22, 28016 Malaga (off-site)
COHR		Tue, Sep 22	Scaling the Optical Future: Technologies Enabling Scale-Up, Scale-Out, and Scale-Across AI Infrastructure	Dr. Julie Eng	Market Focus Theatre: Pavilion 2
NOK			Open XR Optics Forum Industry Update	Not specified	Not specified
COHR			Co-Packaged Optics: From Industry Promise to Reality	Justin Abbott	Market Focus Theatre: Pavilion 2
COHR		13:00-13:55	Increasing Role of Photonics in Next-Generation AIML Interconnects	Dr. Giovanni Barbarossa	Market Focus Theatre: Pavilion 2
COHR		16:00-17:00	Realistic Check of AI Interconnect Scaling Solutions for the Post-1.6T Era	Dr. Sanjai Parthasarathi	Market Focus Theatre: Pavilion 2
COHR		09:00-10:30	Advanced integrated modulators and transmitters: Discrete photonic devices and technologies	Dr. Wilfried Mairneut	E1 Exhibition room 1
COHR	Wed, Sep 23	10:20-10:35	Scaling Ground Station Connectivity for Satellite Constellations	Jessica Wang	Market Focus Theatre: Pavilion 2
CSCO		11:20-11:35	Decoding OF CMS to Simplify Network Management for Coherent Pluggables	Gary Nichol (Distinguished Developer, Cisco)	Market Focus Theater
CIEH		11:40-11:55	The future of coherent optics in the AI era	Frank Chang (Sr. Director, Interconnects Product Line Management)	Not specified
CSCO		12:00-12:55	Panel: The Ethernet Evolution of AI	Mark Nowell (Cisco Fellow)	Market Focus Theater
NOK		12:30-14:00	WP-BEAM: Women in Photonics-Bridging Excellence and Advancement through Mentorship	Jelena Pasic (Director of Patent and Standardization, Network Infrastructure)	C1.4 Conference room 1.4
CIEH		14:00-14:15	Hollow-core fiber at scale - Operational insights from multi-span transmission systems	Andrew Kam (Sr. Manager, Optical Engineering)	Not specified
NOK		14:00-14:45	Inside the AI Fabric: Scaling the Networks Behind Tomorrow's AI Factories	Neel Patel (General Manager, Nokia Optical Component Technology)	Not specified
COHR		15:30-17:00	PAM4 448Gb/s per Lane InP MZM-SOA Array PIC for Next-Generation CPO	Anna Telenczak	PV-P Multipurpose Poster area
CIEH		15:40-15:55	Beyond connectivity - Real-world network sensing with existing optical infrastructure	Helen Xenos (Sr. Director, Portfolio Marketing)	Not specified
COHR		17:00-17:15	2.3Tb/s Backside-Emitting 1060nm VCSEL Array on Silicon Interposer for CPO Applications	Marc Ganshohm	PV-R Multipurpose room
COHR		09:00-10:30	Novel modulators: Discrete Photonic Devices and Technologies	Dr. Wilfried Mairneut (Chair)	A1 Auditorium 1

Source: Company data

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Underweight/Sell	559	15%	93	10%	17%	216	12%
Total	3,694		939			1754	

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INDUSTRY COVERAGE: Telecom & Networking Equipment

COMPANY (TICKER)	RATING (AS OF)	PRICE* (09/17/2026)
Meta A Marshall		
Arista Networks (ANET.N)	O (10/31/2023)	\$199.53
Axon Enterprise Inc (AXON.O)	O (12/03/2024)	\$453.50
Ciena Corporation (CIEN.N)	E (10/10/2025)	\$344.25
Cisco Systems Inc (CSCO.O)	O (04/08/2024)	\$110.24
Coherent Corp (COHR.N)	E (12/13/2023)	\$295.98
Corning Inc (GLW.N)	E (06/13/2024)	\$147.80
F5 Inc (FFIV.O)	E (04/12/2022)	\$434.62
Keysight Technologies Inc (KEYS.N)	O (07/13/2026)	\$331.44
Lumentum Holdings Inc (LITE.O)	E (05/12/2021)	\$893.61
Motorola Solutions Inc (MSI.N)	O (12/17/2025)	\$459.68
Zebra Technologies Corporation (ZBRA.O)	E (12/02/2024)	\$347.81

Stock Ratings are subject to change. Please see latest research for each company.

* Historical prices are not split adjusted.